

Key: The Same Question for Fifty-One Years

84-355 Democracy's Data | GSS confidence | Instructor copy — do not distribute

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All code is given to students. Grade the interpretation.

Structure, as of the rebuild. The brief (`gss-confidence-brief.Rmd`) is now a chapter rather than a parallel copy of the lab: prose organised by argument, under idea headings, with three numbered figures and no numbered steps. The lab (`gss-confidence.Rmd`) still runs Steps 1-10 with the code exposed. **Students should read the brief first. Step numbers below refer to the lab;** the chapter is cited by figure number or section title.

This is the fourth survey lab and the one that completes the set. One instrument up close; one question checked against a public record; many polls at once; and now **one question held still for fifty-one years**. Name that sequence when you open — students should see that “a survey” has been four different objects this term.

Every number below was run against the data files.

The session in one sentence

Confidence in Congress fell from one in four Americans to one in eighteen, most other institutions fell too, the military rose, and the reason we can say any of that is that nobody touched the wording.

The findings

```
g <- cf[cf$institution == "Congress", ]
c(congress_1973 = g$great_deal[g$year == 1973],
  congress_2024 = g$great_deal[g$year == 2024],
  institutions   = nrow(in_),
  survey_years   = length(unique(cf$year)),
  respondents    = 75699)
```

```
#> congress_1973 congress_2024 institutions survey_years respondents
#>           24.1           5.6           13.0           33.0       75699.0
```

```
in_[order(in_$change), c("institution", "change")]
```

```
#>               institution change
#> 6               Medicine -28.6
#> 9       Organized religion -20.2
#> 2               Congress -18.5
#> 4 Executive branch of federal government -17.5
#> 3               Education -17.4
#> 1       Banks and financial institutions -15.7
#> 5               Major companies -15.7
#> 10              Press -15.7
#> 13             U.S. Supreme Court -13.4
#> 12              Television -10.4
#> 11      Scientific community  -4.8
#> 8             Organized labor   1.3
#> 7               Military  10.6
```

- Congress: 24.1% → 5.6%.
- Medicine fell furthest, −28.6. Organized religion −20.2. Congress −18.5.
- The military rose +10.6, peaking at 63.1% in 1991.
- Organized labor +1.3, the scientific community −4.8: essentially flat.

The three things to get said

1. **The value here is the constancy, not the numbers.** Every other trend in this course carries an asterisk — the question changed, the mode changed, the frame changed. **Ask the room what it would take to run the same survey for fifty-one years**, and what an organisation gives up by refusing to modernise a question. The answer is comparability, and it is expensive.

2. **“Trust collapsed” is a sentence the data refuses.** Most fell; one rose sharply; two barely moved. **The single-number version of this story is wrong in an interesting way**, and it is wrong because it averages across institutions with different histories. Same aggregation error as EAVS jurisdictions and pooled redlining tracts, in a new costume.

3. **Medicine, not Congress, is the biggest fall.** Students assume politics is the story. It is not: −28.6 for medicine against −18.5 for Congress. **Let them be surprised, then ask what a fall in confidence in “the people running medicine” is actually measuring** — hospitals, insurers, pharmaceutical companies and doctors are all in there, and the respondent decides which.

The line for the board: a question that never changes is the only way to know the country did.

Handling the room

Lower-temperature than the discrimination unit, but two live wires:

- **The military result** will please some students and unsettle others. Keep it on the timing: it moves with wars, and the 1991 spike is unmistakable.

- **Confidence in science and medicine** invites 2020s arguments. The data ends in 2024 and the series is smoother than students expect. **Show the whole line before anyone theorises about the pandemic** — medicine was falling steadily from 1973, long before.

Walking the steps

Steps	What they do	Min	Watch for
1-3	The question wording, one record, and the scope	8	‘The people running these institutions’ — the ambiguity that runs through everything.
4-5	Congress, 1973 to 2024; then the conclusion they are about to draw	8	Let somebody say ‘Americans have lost faith in everything.’ You need it.
6-7	All thirteen ranked; then the military’s actual series	12	The pivot. Medicine fell most, not Congress. The military rose.
8-9	Where everything stands now; fifty-one years at once	9	The trusted institutions are the technical ones. Ask why.
10	What you can say	5	A report, not a relationship.

Steps 6-7 are the pivot. The military’s 1991 peak is the single most useful number in the file: confidence responds to events, so this is not an irreversible drift in national character.

If you are short on time, protect the pivot and the closing step. The numbers are what make the argument concrete; the sequence is the argument.

Option A — A different institution

Grade on method, not choice.

3/4: Plots one series, identifies its biggest move, offers an event.

4/4: Checks whether the “event” is plausible given the survey timing — GSS fields early in the year, so an event in November shows up in the *next* survey, which may be two years later. **Matching a spike to a headline requires knowing when the interviews happened.**

4/4, best: Notices the danger in the exercise as set. With 13 institutions, 33 survey years and hindsight, **you can always find a story for any move**, and a student who says they cannot distinguish explanation from post-hoc fitting has given the right answer to a slightly unfair question. Reward that.

Option B — The bottom, not the top

Verified output

```
last <- do.call(rbind, lapply(split(cf, cf$institution), function(x) {
  a <- x[x$year == min(x$year), ]; b <- x[x$year == max(x$year), ]
  data.frame(institution = a$institution[1],
             d_great = round(b$great_deal - a$great_deal, 1),
             d_hardly = round(b$hardly_any - a$hardly_any, 1))
}))
last[order(last$d_great), ]
```

```
#>                                     institution
#> Medicine                                     Medicine
#> Organized religion                         Organized religion
#> Congress                                     Congress
#> Executive branch of federal government Executive branch of federal government
#> Education                                     Education
#> Banks and financial institutions           Banks and financial institutions
#> Major companies                             Major companies
#> Press                                         Press
#> U.S. Supreme Court                         U.S. Supreme Court
#> Television                                   Television
#> Scientific community                       Scientific community
#> Organized labor                             Organized labor
#> Military                                     Military
#>                                     d_great d_hardly
#> Medicine                               -28.6    13.9
#> Organized religion                     -20.2    18.4
#> Congress                               -18.5    36.7
#> Executive branch of federal government -17.5    27.7
#> Education                               -17.4    17.7
#> Banks and financial institutions       -15.7    13.4
#> Major companies                        -15.7    12.2
#> Press                                  -15.7    40.5
#> U.S. Supreme Court                     -13.4    21.4
#> Television                             -10.4    25.9
#> Scientific community                    -4.8     5.4
#> Organized labor                         1.3    -3.6
#> Military                                10.6    -5.6
```

3/4: Redoes the ranking on `hardly_any` and reports it differs.

4/4: Names the asymmetry. An institution can shed enthusiasts into “only some” without gaining enemies, or it can polarise — and **the two columns separate indifference from hostility**. Congress does both; some institutions do only the first.

4/4, **best**: Notices the middle category is doing hidden work. “Only some confidence” absorbs everything, so a **three-point scale cannot tell a mild critic from a fence-sitter**, and a fifty-year commitment to three options is the price of comparability. That is the trade the whole lab is about, seen from inside the instrument.

Option C — Ceiling and floor

Verified output

```
l <- cf[cf$institution == "Organized labor", c("year", "great_deal")]
c(first = l$great_deal[1], last = l$great_deal[nrow(l)],
  min = min(l$great_deal), max = max(l$great_deal),
  range = round(max(l$great_deal) - min(l$great_deal), 1))
```

```
#> first  last   min   max range
#> 16.2  17.5   8.4  19.8  11.4
```

Organized labor starts at 16.2 and ends at 17.5 — **a net change of +1.3 that conceals a range of more than ten points.**

And it is the one change in the file that sampling error alone can account for. Figure 2 of the chapter, under *All thirteen, ranked by how far they moved*, draws all thirteen institutions as a first-to-last dumbbell with 95% intervals on each reading; organised labour is the only row whose change is inside its own interval. The defensible sentence about that ranking is therefore *eleven fell, one rose, and one did not move* — not *two rose*. The intervals in that figure assume simple random sampling, which the GSS is not, so they are if anything too narrow.

3/4: Plots it and observes the flat endpoints hide movement.

4/4: Draws the general lesson — **the ranked first-to-last table (the chapter’s *All thirteen, ranked by how far they moved*, Step 6 in the lab) is a first-and-last comparison, which is the crudest possible summary of a 33-point series** — and notes that a different start or end year would reorder the rankings.

4/4, best: Proposes a better summary and defends it: a trend slope, or an average of the first three and last three surveys, both of which are robust to one odd year. **A student who notices that 2021 is the online-mode year and that it sits near the end of every series has found the specific reason to distrust endpoints here.**

Grading

Four-point scale from the syllabus.

- **Never penalise code.** It is your code.
- **The move that earns a 4** is refusing the single-sentence version — noticing that the institutions diverge and that averaging them is the error.
- **A 2** is “Americans have lost trust in everything.” Two of thirteen series say otherwise and one goes the other way.
- **Reward anyone who flags the 2021 mode change** without being told.

Anticipated questions

- “*Why does the series skip years?*” — GSS moved from annual to biennial in 1994 for funding reasons, and 2020 was disrupted. The battery ran in **33** of the 51 years.

- “*What happened in 2021?*” — Face-to-face interviewing was impossible, so GSS went online. **The one methodological break in the series**, and it lands right where students want to draw conclusions about recent years.
- “*Is ‘a great deal’ the right measure?*” — It is one of three. Option B is exactly this question; do not settle it for them.
- “*Does this predict anything?*” — Not from here. Nothing in this file links confidence to behaviour — not turnout, not compliance, not vote choice.
- “*Why is medicine in a politics course?*” — Because it is the control. It shows that whatever happened, it was not confined to politics.

Connections

- **The CES lab** — one instrument, up close, and the weighting problem.
- **The CPS turnout lab** — one question checked against a public record; there the survey could be *graded*, here it cannot.
- **Polls, models and markets** — many instruments at once.
- **EAVS and redlining** — averaging across units with different histories, and what it destroys.